

Corporate marketing leaders: the key attributes

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In the past decade, there has been an increasing interest in marketing's role in the firm and its influence in the organization. There is concern that marketing has become decentralized and has "lost its seat at the table". At the highest levels of marketing leadership, the position of Chief Marketing Officer (CMO), tenure is just 26 months compared to 44 months for CEOs. Approximately 50 percent of *Fortune* 1000 firms have a CMO position in contrast to more than 80 percent of such firms having a CFO position. The Starbucks Corporation re-staffed its head of marketing position five times in the past seven years. Coca-Cola changed its CMO four times in six years, and FedEx-Kinko's has staffed the position three times in five years. Moreover, Burger King, Allstate, Circuit City, Avon, Revlon, and Yahoo! have all recruited new CMOs recently. This all begs the question: what exactly makes a marketing leader successful? Greg Welch, a recruiter from Spencer Stuart, states that marketers need to "think less about doing and concentrate on leading". Therefore, before taking on the task of what makes a CMO successful, it is first necessary to understand the attributes and characteristics of high performing leadership in the marketing organization and beyond. This paper seeks to understand the leadership qualities important to the marketing function and compare them to those found important in other business functions.

The job of a marketing leader

Well before reaching the level of CMO, marketers have the unique boundary-spanning job of interacting with other functions of the organization. Traditionally, marketing is charged with advertising and promotional campaigns, relaying customer information through out the firm, and new product launches. In many of today's marketing operations, cross-functional and diverse teams are necessary for producing the best results. Success in customer relationship management (CRM) requires marketing and sales to work with information technology. New product development and innovation takes collaboration from marketing, R&D, and manufacturing. In terms of production, marketing and manufacturing must work together to ensure quality products and a manageable product demand schedule. Maintaining a customer orientation in the organization requires input and assistance from various functional departments. In short, organizational performance is linked to diverse but collaborative work groups. This interfunctional cooperation is often critical to realizing company goals. But managers and team leaders heading up these types of teams often find difficulty owing to interpersonal skill sets, perceptions of work load fairness, leadership styles and of course stereotypes held about other functional departments.

In order for marketers to perform the boundary-spanning work in which they were charged, they must understand the entire value chain thoroughly, including engineering and manufacturing. It is through this understanding that marketers are better equipped to guide activities across the entire value chain. However, it has been said that different functional

areas are like different “thought worlds” (Homburg and Jensen, 2007; Strahle *et al.*, 1996). If senior marketers are to guide junior marketers or lead cross-functional teams there should be an understanding of what individuals from different departments deem as effective leadership. This does not mean that a marketing manager is going to change his or her leadership style automatically. It does mean that the marketer can assess his leadership style and determine how it impacts the effectiveness of cross-functional teams and the overall productivity.

The successful marketing leader must align the goals of the firm's departments in the best interest of the company. When all functional units have an understanding of the strategy the result is improved organizational performance. But how is this achieved when units have their own goals and preconceptions? We propose a look at the type of leadership that is most effective in marketing departments and across other functional units. What are the perceptions of high-performing leadership across business function? Equipped with this understanding a manager can better understand how to interact, lead, and work cross-functionally.

Leadership 101

From past research, we know that executives who promote an innovative product or process in their company are likely to articulate ideological goals, show confidence in others and display self-confidence. In doing so, they are viewed as leaders. A study of interdepartmental interactions on product quality by Menon *et al.* (1997) reports that a willingness to take risks on the part of managers may encourage employees to take risks and lead to greater organizational innovation. Additionally, managers should use reward systems to take into account the contributions of individuals in improving product quality. Encouraging a market orientation throughout the firm requires a leader willing to communicate his support to junior employees, take risks, and provide reward systems to encourage a market orientation.

In the leadership literature, characteristics such as honesty and intelligence are important across the board. But what about being analytic or charismatic or supportive? Charismatic leaders influence external support for their organizations. Although this is valuable at the c-suite level, how important is charisma for a marketing manager? Should a marketing manager expect that leadership style will transfer across business function? Like the theory of charismatic leadership, there are other well-documented leadership theories in marketing. One such theory is transformational leadership, which transforms the beliefs, values, and aspirations of employees (Bass, 1985). These leaders have a vision, create excitement, and motivate their followers to perform beyond expectations in order to meet the collective goals and objectives communicated by the leader. Transformational leadership consists of four characteristics: idealized influence (known as charisma), inspirational motivation, intellectual stimulation and individualized consideration. Transformational leadership has been linked with increased customer-oriented selling by representatives, project team innovations, and the achievement of business unit financial goals. Beyond the well-known leadership theories there are a host of attributes, traits, and characteristics associated with effective leadership that we consider in this study.

The dimensions of leadership

Our research was designed to uncover the dimensions of marketing leadership that lead to perceptions of high performance. We collected data from two large multinational companies across various business functions. Over 1,000 employees responded to an online survey and 825 responses from six functional departments (engineering, information technology, manufacturing, marketing, sales, and research) were used in the initial analysis. The employees were asked to rate the importance of 45 leadership attributes to high-performing leadership in their particular business function. The attribute list was created from previous leadership studies, interviews with high-ranking marketing executives during a conference,

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and further refined using input from executive MBA students at a large Midwestern university. Given the focus on marketing for this research we added “customer orientation” to the attributes rated. However, we did not include it in determining the leadership dimensions.

In order to better understand the data the 45 attributes were factor analyzed to reduce redundancy and identify any coherent underlying patterns. This analysis was performed on the four business functions having significantly higher samples sizes (engineering, manufacturing, marketing, R&D). This analysis yielded a nine-factor solution. After examining the results the nine factors are labeled: “Charisma”, “Supportive”, “Responsible”, “Vision”, “Integrity”, “Creative”, “Intelligent”, “Challenges the Process”, and “Risk Taking”. The leadership dimensions are defined as follows:

1. *Charisma* refers to leaders who not only exude charisma but are extroverted, energetic, and enthusiastic. These individuals are sociable and self-confident.
2. *Supportive*. Supportive leaders are caring, have concern for individuals and are team-oriented. They are friendly and considerate and help employees further their careers. When tasks are stressful and boring, supportive leaders increase employee satisfaction by increasing self-confidence and lowering anxiety.
3. *Responsible*. Responsible leadership is described by self-control, self-renewal (the ability to learn from one's mistakes), emotional maturity, and open-mindedness. These leaders are sensitive to the environment and understand how resources impact their team's job.
4. *Vision*. The vision dimension reflects the leader who can articulate a vision for the future and serve as a role model. This person inspires and motivates employees, shows sound judgment and provides rewards and recognition for good performance.
5. *Integrity*. A manager with integrity is honest, dependable, fair-minded, and uses good judgment. This is the number one most admired characteristic across studies on leadership.
6. *Creative*. Imaginative leaders who demonstrate independent thinking, intuition, and who are intellectually stimulating are considered creative.
7. *Intelligent*. Intelligence in a business leader does not mean understanding the ins and outs of every job function but refers to a leader who understands the business and takes time to learn the current operations before making organizational changes. Intelligent managers are characterized by their analytic ability, ambition, organization, and perception.
8. *Challenges the process*. This manager recognizes and supports good ideas and has the willingness to challenge the system in order to get new products, processes, and services adopted. These leaders also show confidence in others and have high expectations for their followers. Challenging the process involves seeking new challenges and finding new and better ways of doing things.
9. *Risk takers*. The risk-taking leader uses unconventional behavior to get things done and does not mind incurring personal risk for the sake of the organization.

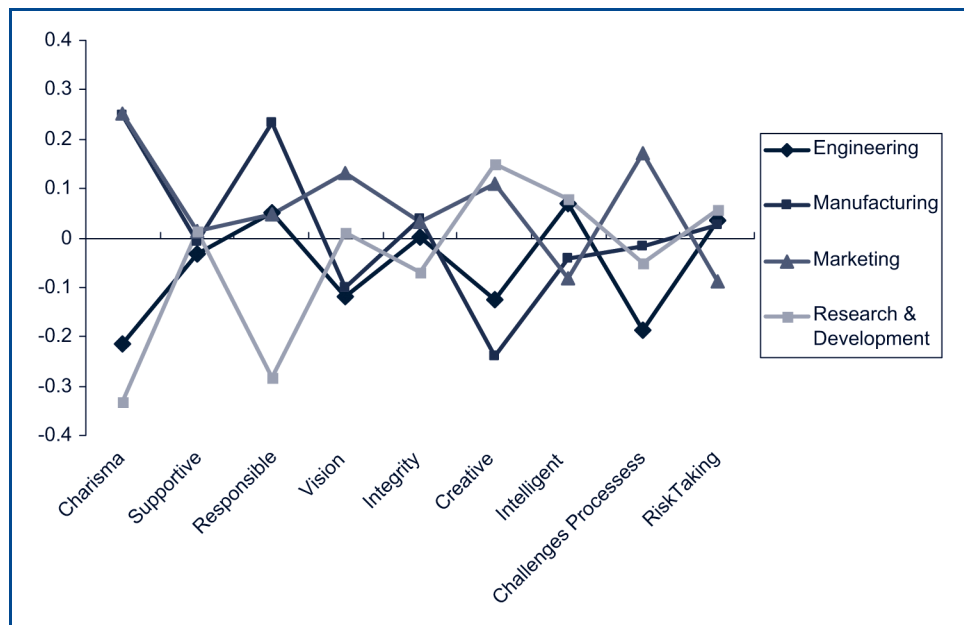
The marketer as leader

Next we determine if all the business functions feel similarly about these nine dimensions or if there are differing perceptions of what makes for a good leader. An analysis of variance procedures reveals that five of the nine dimensions differ statistically across business function. However, support, integrity, intelligence, and risk-taking show no statistical differences in terms of their importance to our four functional departments. Thus, marketers, engineers, manufacturers and R&D personnel all feel similarly about the importance of these four leadership dimensions and their impact on high-performing leadership in their respective functional areas. We refer to these four leader characteristics as “common” dimensions of leadership since all four business functions feel equally regarding their importance to high-performing leadership.

There are also “distinctive” leadership dimensions. These are the attributes and behaviors that are unique to a particular functional unit. Out of the nine leadership dimensions, four are deemed more important in marketing compared to the other business functions. The four dimensions are charisma, vision, creativity, and challenging the process. Figure 1 displays the nine leadership dimensions by business function.

1. The marketing leader needs charisma to move the organization into a market- oriented approach that puts the customers first. Marketers must also influence other departments, as when a marketer convinces an engineer of what the customer wants and needs in a new product. The charismatic leader is known for encouraging individuals to work for the greater good of the company. We might expect a leader with charisma to have the ability to “rally the troops” from shop room to board room where more and more marketing VPs and chief marketing officers interact with the company's top management team.
2. Vision is not only the manager's view of the future but the ability to articulate this view as an attractive and realistic future for employees. This is the forward-thinking and forward-looking marketer who can enlist others to adopt and carry out the vision. When Chipotle hired its first CMO a few years ago, Chipotle's founder, Steve Eells, said he was bringing on a chief marketing officer to “strengthen our marketing *vision* – which has not kept pace with what we have been doing with food and with people – and will help us establish deeper and more meaningful connections with new and existing customers”.

Figure 1



The visionary manager inspires and motivates followers, uses sound judgment and behaves as a role model.

3. Creative leaders include not just the person working with the ad agency or even the imaginative or creative thinker. Not all marketing executives can come up with a clever tagline or a breakthrough advertising campaign. The leadership dimension of creativity also points to someone who, in addition to possessing creative thinking, is intellectually stimulating, intuitive, and independent.
4. Challenging the process is probably the marketing manager's toughest but most important job. It is the marketer who must keep the organization focused on the customer. He or she has the willingness to challenge the traditional ways of doing things. Other attributes defining this leadership dimension are challenging expectations or showing confidence in others and possessing high performance expectations. This person is also courageous and determined.

The *Marketing Hall of Legends* in Canada recognizes outstanding marketers each year. They have four categories of winners and two of them correspond with our leadership dimensions. The first is "visionary," designed to honor entrepreneurs and the second is "builders" for "charismatic leaders who have built and enhanced existing brands". The other two are designated for market communications specialists and those marketers who have served as mentors to others.

Shared leadership characteristics

The four leadership dimensions (charisma, vision, creative, challenges the process) we identified for marketers are not entirely unique to this business function. Individuals in manufacturing, as in marketing, value charisma in a leader. Both marketing and R&D agree on the importance of creativity. Engineering and marketing managers appear to agree only on the importance of responsible leadership and do not see it as affecting high-performing leadership for their business units. Manufacturers, however, think highly of responsible leaders, defined by self-control, learning from one's mistakes and emotional maturity. Marketing deviates most from engineering in terms of the importance it gives leadership ratings. On the four leadership dimensions that marketing finds most important to high-performing leadership, engineering tends to rate them fairly low.

Before determining the dimensions of leadership we also looked at the individual ratings on the attributes. Table I shows the top ten leadership ratings as determined by marketing in the first column with the corresponding ratings given by five other business functions (engineering, information technology, manufacturing, research & development, and sales) in the remaining columns. Here, being customer-oriented was included among the attributes rated. Four of the five business functions ranked honesty/integrity as the most important leadership characteristic, in keeping with the vast majority of studies on leadership. On average, employees in information technology selected competency as the most important attribute. Competency is rated highly by the other four functional areas as well. While

Table I						
Attribute	Mkt	Engine	IT	Manuf	R&D	Sales
Honesty/Integrity	1	1	2	1	1	1
Competent	2	2	1	4	2	4
Customer oriented	3	16	10	10	15	2
Good judgment	4	3	3	2	3	8
Effective	5	5	4	3	4	5
Articulate	6	8	7	6	7	3
Vision	7	10	22	7	6	9
Dependable	8	4	5	5	9	12
Open-minded	9	7	17	11	8	22
Challenges the process	10	11	36	15	13	13

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marketers ranked customer orientation third, it was ranked 17th with engineers, 11th by manufacturing, and R&D professionals ranked it 15th. This finding reflects the work that marketing must do in making customer orientation a priority in the organization and the work that management must do in supporting marketing in this endeavor. Not shown in Table II are the findings that engineering and R&D rank “analytical” 5th in terms of its importance to high-performing leadership although it comes in 32nd with marketing and 30th with manufacturing. This points to a common problem in marketing, the inability to quantify marketing results. Marketers need to get a better handle on analytics to help when dealing with the more quantitative units in the firm.

In sum, all marketers must aspire to leadership. Of the nine dimensions of leadership, four are more important in marketing compared to the other functional departments. From the findings here we can conclude that employees in marketing feel their leader should possess charisma, creativity, articulate an appealing vision, and challenge the traditional ways of doing things in order to be considered a high performing marketing leader. These findings suggest that marketing recognizes the need for upper management to play a leadership role not only in the functional area but across the organization.

The marketing manager who wants to lead effectively should focus not only on dimensions distinct to marketing but on common leadership dimensions as well. As Landry *et al.* (2006) suggest, the marketing manager should aspire to be a business leader and not just a marketing leader. The dimensions essential to all four functional departments include a leader who is supportive, possesses integrity, intelligence, and is willing to take risks. By understanding other functional areas, in essence the entire value chain, the marketer is prepared to work cross-functionally and take an active leadership role in the company. Marketers also need to become better versed in analytics to quantify marketing's contributions and communicate with engineers and R&D on a leadership dimension deemed important. Marketers at all levels, not only the executive tier, can begin to work cross-functionally, engage in collaborative behavior, and exemplify the dimensions of leadership distinct to their own business unit as well as those shared or common leadership dimensions deemed important to high-performing leadership across business functions. It is through this understanding and behavior that marketers can move from just “doing” to leading.

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